1. Leverage of existing IT assets: With increased organisational emphasis on cost control, the ability to reuse and leverage existing technology and infrastructure is a huge plus since it not only helps optimise capital expenditure but also reduces the difficulty of transitioning to a new paradigm.

2. Maturity of technology: Technology maturity often has a direct correlation to ease of installation, deployment and management. IT managers responsible for ensuring application and infrastructure reliability tend to value technology maturity over novelty.

3. Potential benefits and utility: Evaluating a trend or technology on this parameter helps organisations sift hype from reality. Issues like return-on-investment and time-to-market are important considerations here.

4. Cost of implementation: Superior or new technologies often come at a significant cost, or can become expensive to deploy. A discrete assessment (of the technology) on cost considerations ensures its relevance.

We now present the Top 10 Technologies that will matter this year.

1 Security 2.0

Just protecting devices in the network will not suffice – the focus of security needs to be the data

As 2010 sees uptake of several community-based technology and communication paradigms like UC, TP and Social Media, the traditional perimeter security models will need to change and give way to a paradigm that is more user-driven and user-propagated.

Information dissemination and user awareness will play a more important role, and IT managers will need to pay more attention to implementing security policies in a relatively open and dynamic IT framework.

Now that the boundaries of enterprise networks are no longer rigid, with partner and client networks meeting in fuzzy zones, protecting devices in the network is not enough. Even protecting the servers and storage devices that contain data will not suffice—the focus of security has to be on data.

IT Next is of the view that it would be meaningful to develop security policies that lay greater emphasis on data and information protection, followed by endpoint protection and network protection. Essentially, it is about having data at the center of the security policy.

It would be advantageous for IT managers to use the social media and integrated communication tools to sensitise users about security policies, and develop security champions for addressing security-related concerns in the dynamic enterprise.

2 Business Intelligence and Analytics

While BI can help analyse business information better, the value is in performing a predictive analysis

The economic crisis that caught many enterprises and governments unprepared, also spawned the realisation that a greater use of BI and BA tools could have facilitated a speedier damage control in the aftermath of the crisis.

Market intelligence teams in enterprises are now placing greater emphasis on such tools to help their organisations captivate on new opportunities as the economy recovers.

While business intelligence focuses on monitoring operational information for understanding the gaps and taking corrective measures, business analytics aims to perform a predictive analysis of the market and the business.

In today's globalised and highly competitive marketplace, BI and BA tools can help your organisation compete better. Line managers increasingly rely on their IT counterparts for improved performance management.

IT Next urges you to evaluate and recommend BI/BA tools that can be neatly integrated with your enterprise IT systems, and help market intelligence and marketing teams in your organisation use the data to formulate smart growth strategies.

3 Data Center Transformation

Virtualisation, server rationalisation, site consolidation, and energy management are ideal ingredients of a data center transformation recipe

While 'measured green' alone would be a good enough reason to initiate a data center transformation, there are other equally strong reasons to do it. These include measurable cost savings, improved productivity and efficiency across the organisation.

The ideal ingredients for a data center transformation would include virtualisation, server rationalisation, site consolidation, and energy management.

IT Next advises IT managers to develop a data center transformation roadmap that will distribute the capital expenditure (capex) over a period of years while ensuring return on investments for each year or a periodic interval. For example, you could identify inefficient and energy hogging servers and chart a phased plan to replace these by smart form factor servers that are more efficient.

Data centers often operate with more-than-surplus cooling equipment, to fight off 'hot spots' that get built up in certain zones due to air-flow deficiencies. Experts have pointed out that most data centers suffer from the problem of over-loading and that the solution lies in identifying the hot spots and creating airflow in those zones. You could draw measurable benefits by installing energy monitoring and management software in the data center.

4 Virtualisation

A virtualisation strategy will help you get the best out of your IT infrastructure. Evaluate and perform a mid-term adjustment, if necessary

Given that the most pronounced goal of virtualisation is to leverage existing IT infrastructure and reduce buying, its relevance for you as an IT manager will continue to be very high in the prevailing economic situation. So, stick to your virtualisation roadmap, and do the necessary adjustments and refinements, if you are already working on one. If not, put your virtualisation act together, especially if you have a data center to manage.

In general, server and storage virtualisation will make immediate sense because redundancy of these resources is usually high in many organisations in India.

Adoption of desktop virtualisation and application virtualisation would work on a small scale, at least through 2010. One, because for virtualised desktop